

My newly naked, sensitive glans penis was protected from irritation with bandages. Slowly the area lost its sensitivity and as it did I realized I had lost something rather vital. Stimuli that had previously aroused ecstasy had relatively little effect. There was a short period of depression but acceptance of the situation developed, as it had to. The acute sensitivity never returned, something rather precious to a sensual hedonist had been forever lost.

So, I hope you will do what you can to discourage circumcision. My experience and reading indicate that the operation is not only medically unnecessary in the great majority of cases but also that circumcision destroys a very joyful aspect of the human experience for both males and females.

Another man wrote saying he'd been "deprived" of his foreskin at the age of 26. He claimed,

If American men who were circumcised at birth could know the deprivation of pleasure that they would experience, they would storm the hospitals and not permit their sons to undergo this unnecessary loss. But how can they know this? You have to be circumcised as an adult, as I was, to realize what a terrible loss of pleasure results from this cruel operation.

With the growing body of evidence suggesting lifelong physical and psychological damage from circumcision, the American medical community should be taking a responsible role in bringing the practice to an end. However, circumcision has become a political issue in America where this \$200 million a year business continues to flourish. In England, on the other hand, when the British Health Service stopped paying for it, the circumcision rate dropped to less than one-half on one percent. While this might suggest there is a profit motive here, money isn't the only compelling factor in this complex issue.

It may be easier to live in denial than to face the atrocious act we commit on more than one million baby boys each year, an act that has affected the majority of American men. In deciding not to circumcise his son, one father wrote,

What was so difficult in leaving my son intact was not that my son would feel different in a locker room, but that I would feel different from him. I would then have to accept that I'm an amputee from the wars of a past generation.

Unfortunately, not all men can commit to such self-evaluation. When it became evident that some fathers - and mothers - would cling to a cultural ritual regardless of what their babies would endure, circumcision became an infant rights issue. A precedent lawsuit was filed in 1984 which asked: "Does a parent have the power to consent to a surgical procedure which has no medical purpose?" But, it is difficult to find justice with respect to an unjust act in a system that culturally accepts that act. It has now become necessary to go beyond that system.

A resolution was passed unanimously at The First International Symposium on Circumcision which will move the issue of male and female circumcision to the World Court, The Hague. The intention of the resolution is to have the World Court declare that male/female genital mutilations conducted for reasons other than medical necessity are de facto violations of Article 5 of